CHAPTER 7 · DEEP DIVE · A HOUSE DIVIDED

Fort Sumter

The first shots of the Civil War — and the clever trap that forced the South to fire them. April 1861.

Name: _____ **Period:** _____ **Date:** _____

The first shots of the Civil War — and the clever trap that forced the South to fire them. April 1861.

If you knew war was coming, would you fire the first shot — or make the other side do it?

A Fort in a Hostile Harbor

THE STANDOFF

By March 1861, seven Southern states had left the Union. But the United States still held a few forts on Southern soil — and the most important was Fort Sumter, a brick fortress on an island in the middle of Charleston Harbor, South Carolina.

The small U.S. garrison inside was running low on food. Lincoln faced a trap with no good exit: abandon the fort and accept that the Confederacy was a real country, or send in troops and be blamed for starting a war.

"Bombardment of Fort Sumter, Charleston Harbor, April 12 & 13, 1861" — lithograph, Currier & Ives, 1861, public domain (Library of Congress).

A Message, Not an Army

LINCOLN'S MOVE

Lincoln found a third path. He announced he would send only food — "provisions" — to the hungry men inside. No weapons, no soldiers, no reinforcements. Just bread.

Now the decision belonged to the Confederacy. If they let the food through, they looked weak. If they attacked a resupply of food, they would fire the war's first shot in front of the whole world. Lincoln had handed them the choice — and the blame.

The divided nation, 1861 — map, © ShadowDog Digital Studios (SDS Digital Collection).

The Bombardment of Fort Sumter

APRIL 12–13, 1861

For 34 hours Confederate guns ringing the harbor pounded the fort. Remarkably, no one on either side was killed in the battle itself. The war that followed would not be so merciful.

"Bombardment of Fort Sumter, Charleston Harbor, April 12 & 13, 1861" — lithograph, Currier & Ives, 1861, public domain (Library of Congress).

The South Takes the Bait

THE DECISION

Confederate President Jefferson Davis ordered the fort taken before the food arrived. At 4:30 a.m. on April 12, 1861, Confederate cannon opened fire. After a day and a half of bombardment, the U.S. garrison surrendered.

The Confederacy had its fort — but it had also fired first. The effect was instant and enormous: the North, divided and hesitant the day before, was suddenly united in fury.

"Bombardment of Fort Sumter, Charleston Harbor, April 12 & 13, 1861" — lithograph, Currier & Ives, 1861, public domain (Library of Congress).

ABRAHAM LINCOLN · APRIL 15, 1861

I call forth the militia of the several States of the Union, to the aggregate number of seventy-five thousand, in order to … suppress [the] combinations [against the laws].

— PROCLAMATION CALLING FOR 75,000 VOLUNTEERS

One Shot, a Whole War

THE CHAIN REACTION

Lincoln called for 75,000 volunteers to put down the rebellion. That call forced every remaining slave state to choose a side — and four more (Virginia, Arkansas, Tennessee, and North Carolina) seceded rather than send troops against fellow Southerners.

A single decision in one harbor had set off a chain: resupply → attack → surrender → call for troops → four more states gone. The argument was over. The war had begun.

"Bombardment of Fort Sumter, Charleston Harbor, April 12 & 13, 1861" — lithograph, Currier & Ives, 1861, public domain (Library of Congress).

Follow the Dominoes

YOUR TURN

You'll trace the chain of cause and effect that turned a food shipment into a civil war — and judge whether Lincoln outmaneuvered the South or provoked it.